



Stunning comeback: From languishing at the bottom of the standings after the sixth round to finishing on top of the podium, Praggnanandhaa's was an effort a player could only dream of. MICHAL WALUSZA/FIDE

the classical format with some splendid play.

"He won the last four classical games. That's as clutch as it gets. Pragg is an incredible fighter and it is fun to see him get rewarded for that," Carlsen, who is not known to throw praise around, said while congratulating the champion.

The Norwegian, who has been World No. 1 since July 2011 and has dominated the sport, winning almost everything on offer, looked a pale shadow of himself in Oslo as he struggled to close out games that he would have wrapped up rather easily at other times.

For Praggnanandhaa, it was the kind of comeback a player could only dream of — from languishing at the bottom of the standings after the sixth round to finishing on top of the podium.

The young Indian will savour this victory because he has not had the

best of times over the past year or so. Perhaps the Oslo special could prove to be the catalyst for bigger things to come.

After the initial setbacks in the tournament, nothing fundamentally changed in his approach, he said.

But he did make a key adjustment that brought about a change in fortunes after the tepid start.

"A conscious effort to play faster certainly helped in my games. I had more time than my opponents in most of the games," he said.

To get the better of Frenchman Alireza Firouzja, Carlsen, Gukesh and Keymer in succession — and convincingly at that — was an indication of the quality of his play and how good he can be on his day.

Praggnanandhaa is known to be highly resilient and possesses a rich repertoire of openings and elite defensive skills to complement his attacking instincts. All these qualities

were on display in the tournament as he rose from the ashes like a phoenix with such stunning efficiency that it left his opponents searching for answers.

Looking ahead to the coming months, Praggnanandhaa said he plans to play fewer tournaments than last year to better manage his schedule and workload.

However, he confirmed that he will feature in the World Rapid Team Championship for Chess Gurukul, scheduled from June 16 to 22 in Hong Kong.

During the tournament, he had spoken about overcoming the disappointment of a below-par performance in the Candidates and the toll of playing too many tournaments.

He said he felt the need to take breaks as he had been playing constantly and would think about it at some point. Maybe a call with his